

macOS Terminal: Command Reference Guide

Technical Documentation

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Navigation & Directory Listing

pwd

Prints the current working directory path to the terminal.

```
$ pwd
```

ls -la

Lists all files in the current directory, including hidden files (starting with .), with detailed permissions and sizes.

```
$ ls -la
```

File & Folder Management

mkdir

Creates a new folder or directory at the specified path (e.g., project_folder).

```
$ mkdir project_folder
```

touch

Creates a new, empty file.

```
$ touch newfile.txt
```

cp

Copies a file or directory from the source to the destination.

```
$ cp file.txt /path/to/destination/
```

mv

Moves or renames a file or directory.

```
$ mv old.txt new.txt
```

rm -r

Removes a directory and all its contents recursively (e.g., old_folder). Use with extreme caution.

```
$ rm -r old_folder
```

File Content & Output

cat

Displays the entire contents of a file directly in the terminal window.

```
$ cat file.txt
```

echo

Prints text to the terminal or appends it to a file using redirection.

```
$ echo "Hello World" > file.txt
```

System & Application Automation

open App

Launches a specific application from the terminal by name.

```
$ open -a "Photo Booth"
```

open File

Opens a file using its default system application.

```
$ open /path/to/file
```

AppleScript Finder Open

Uses the macOS Open Scripting Architecture (osascript) to command Finder to open a specific folder.

```
$ osascript -e 'tell application "Finder" to open folder "Documents"'
```